RHODE ISLAND

The Ocean State



Rhode Island has never done things quite like everyone else, and its food is no exception.

When English settlers arrived in the 1630s, drawn by Roger Williams' promise of religious tolerance and a fresh start along Narragansett Bay, they came ashore hungry and uncertain. The land was forested and unfamiliar, the winters unforgiving. It was the Narragansett people who had already mastered this landscape—and it was their knowledge that kept the early colonists alive. Among the most valuable things the Narragansett shared was their deep understanding of corn, which they called nasaump. They dried it, cracked it, and ground it into a coarse meal that could be cooked over an open fire into a simple, sustaining cake. The settlers, practical and desperate in equal measure, paid close attention.

The Narragansett had cultivated a specific variety of white flint corn in the glacially deposited, well-drained soils of South County—particularly in the areas around Charlestown and Usquepaugh, where the land and climate produced a grain with a distinctive sweetness and a fine, dense texture unlike any other corn grown in the colonies. That terroir, as particular as any in the world, is what gave the Rhode Island johnny cake its character. Settlers learned to grind the white flint corn on stone mills, the most famous of which, Gray's Grist Mill in Adamsville, has been operating continuously since 1675—making it the oldest grist mill in America and still producing the same stone-ground meal today.

The cakes themselves became a cornerstone of colonial Rhode Island life. Cooked on a hearthside griddle or a flat stone set near the fire, they required little more than meal, boiling water, and salt—humble ingredients that produced something far greater than their simplicity suggested. Sailors and travelers carried them as provisions, earning the cakes the nickname "journey cakes," which over generations softened into "johnny cakes" on the lips of Rhode Islanders who made them every morning without a second thought. Inland families in Washington County ate them one way—thick, dense, and tender. Families closer to Newport and the bay preferred them thin and lacy at the edges, almost crisp. That debate, thick versus thin, has never been fully resolved, and Rhode Islanders remain cheerfully passionate about it to this day.

By the 18th and 19th centuries, the johnny cake was so woven into Rhode Island identity that it was practically a point of pride—a way of saying we are from here, and here is different. The white flint corn that made them possible remains nearly unique to this small state, still grown in the same South County fields, still milled on stone, still non-negotiable among purists who insist that no other corn meal will do.

When you make this dish, you are reaching back through nearly four centuries of American history—to a Narragansett fire, a colonial hearth, a sailor's pocket, and a South County kitchen. Few foods carry that kind of weight so lightly. The batter comes together in minutes, the griddle does the rest, and what you end up with is golden, slightly crisp at the edges, and deeply, quietly satisfying in a way that is difficult to explain until you taste it for yourself.

JOHNNYCAKES

Thin, crisp, and stone-ground, the Rhode Island johnnycake is proof the state has never done anything quite like everyone else.

Yield: 8–10 johnnycakes

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup Kenyon's or Gray's white stone-ground cornmeal
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 cup boiling water (approx., see note)
- ¼ cup milk (or more, for thinning)
- Butter or bacon fat (for frying)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Combine dry ingredients*: In a mixing bowl, stir together cornmeal and salt.
2. *Add hot water*: Pour boiling water gradually into the cornmeal while stirring, until it forms a thick but spoonable batter (like hot cereal). Let it rest 5–10 minutes.
3. *Adjust texture*: Stir in milk a little at a time until the batter is smooth and the consistency of thick pancake batter. It should slowly spread when spooned onto the griddle, but not run.
4. *Heat griddle*: Heat a cast iron skillet or griddle over medium heat. Add a small amount of butter or bacon fat.
5. *Cook*: Spoon 2 Tbsp of batter per cake onto the hot skillet. Flatten slightly with the back of a spoon. Cook 6–8 minutes per side, until golden brown and crisp. Turn carefully—they're delicate until browned.
6. *Serve hot*: With butter and maple syrup, or as a side to savory breakfast meats or baked beans.

